

THE FUTURIST'S STRATEGY CONE™

A Human-Controlled Governance Framework for Agentic AI in Internal Audit

4 STAGES: Risk → Audit → Evidence → Reporting

CONCEPTUAL RESEARCH FRAMEWORK

01 RISK
02 AUDIT
03 EVIDENCE
04 REPORTING

Agentic AI Audit Leader
Predictive Intelligence
Real-time Assurance
Stronger Governance

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Creator of THE FUTURIST'S STRATEGY CONE™

Designed for Boards, CFOs & CAEs to Govern Agentic AI with Confidence
AI Enhances Capability. Humans Maintain Accountability.

Explore the Framework
Scan to learn more

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THE FUTURIST'S STRATEGY CONE™ v7.0

Enterprise Reference Edition

An Independent Governance Framework for Responsible Agentic AI Adoption

Version: 7.0

Edition: Enterprise Reference Edition

Author: Adnan Shamim

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Document Type: Independent Governance Framework

By Adnan Shamim

Document Purpose

Artificial Intelligence is evolving from automation tools into autonomous systems capable of planning, reasoning, coordinating, and executing increasingly complex activities. As organizations adopt Agentic AI, governance must evolve beyond traditional technology controls to establish clear accountability, effective oversight, and adaptable decision structures.

THE FUTURIST'S STRATEGY CONE™ v7.0 presents an independent governance framework that integrates governance, enterprise risk management, internal audit, compliance, and operational oversight into a single governance architecture designed to support responsible Agentic AI adoption.

The framework is intended as a reference architecture that organizations can adapt to their governance maturity, regulatory obligations, technology environment, and business objectives.

Executive Summary

The Enterprise Reference Edition represents the latest evolution of **THE FUTURIST'S STRATEGY CONE™**.

Rather than treating AI governance as a technology initiative alone, the framework positions governance as an enterprise capability requiring coordinated leadership across boards, executive management, risk, compliance, technology, and internal audit.

The framework introduces Dynamic Decision Boundaries as a governance mechanism that enables organizations to define, monitor, evaluate, and recalibrate AI decision authority while maintaining continuous human accountability.

Version 7.0 expands the framework through:

- Governance of both single-agent and multi-agent AI ecosystems.
- Enterprise integration with governance, risk, compliance, identity, and operational platforms.
- Continuous governance monitoring and decision boundary recalibration.
- Human-centered accountability supported by clearly defined governance responsibilities.
- Independent assurance through Internal Audit.
- Operational resilience through monitoring, change governance, and controlled deployment.

The framework is intended to support organizations throughout the lifecycle of enterprise AI adoption—from initial pilots to mature enterprise-scale deployments.

Guiding Principle

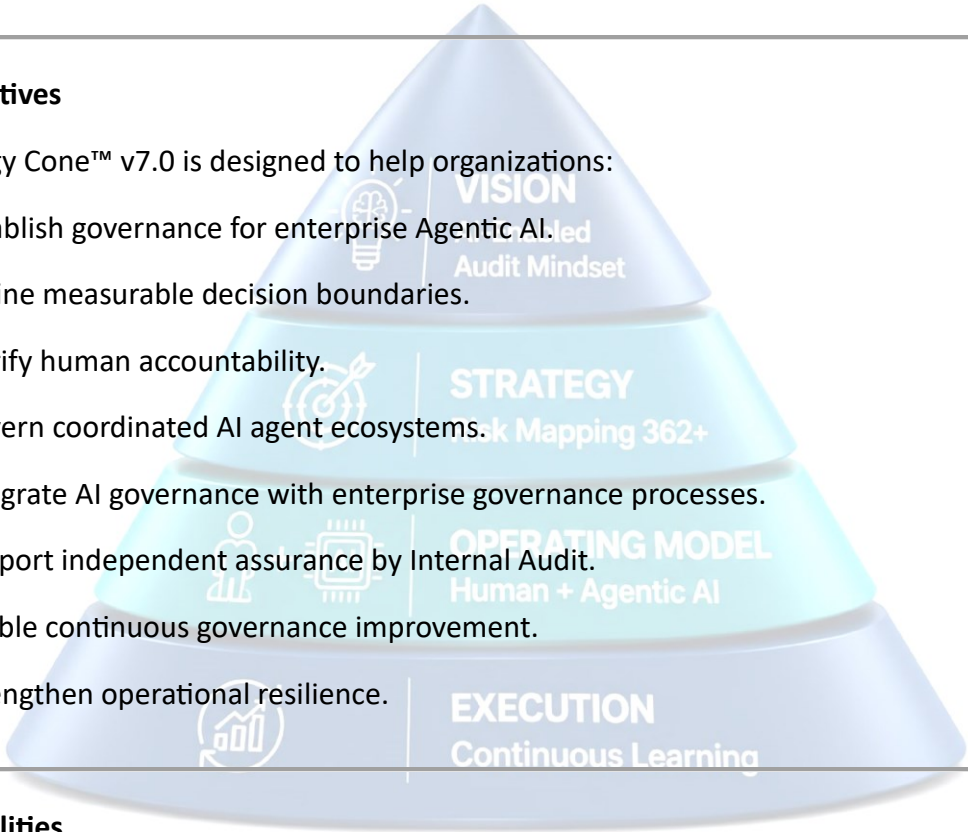
AI Works. Humans Decide. Decision Boundaries Are Dynamic. Accountability Always Remains Human.

This principle reflects the central philosophy of the framework:

Artificial intelligence may enhance analysis, coordination, and decision support, but accountability for organizational outcomes remains with authorized human decision-makers.

Core Objectives

The Strategy Cone™ v7.0 is designed to help organizations:

- 
- Establish governance for enterprise Agentic AI.
 - Define measurable decision boundaries.
 - Clarify human accountability.
 - Govern coordinated AI agent ecosystems.
 - Integrate AI governance with enterprise governance processes.
 - Support independent assurance by Internal Audit.
 - Enable continuous governance improvement.
 - Strengthen operational resilience.
-

Key Capabilities

The framework introduces guidance for:

- Dynamic Decision Boundary Governance
- Human Accountability Architecture
- Multi-Agent Governance
- Enterprise Integration

- Change Governance
- Continuous Monitoring
- Internal Audit Assurance
- Predictive Risk Sensing
- Operational Resilience
- Governance Lifecycle Management

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SECTION 1 — Executive Governance & Strategy Layer

1.1 Governance Philosophy

The Strategy Cone™ v7.0 is founded on a simple principle:

Technology may execute. Humans remain accountable.

Enterprise AI governance should ensure that autonomous capabilities improve organizational performance without weakening transparency, accountability, professional judgement, or oversight.

The framework therefore emphasizes governance before automation.

1.2 Governance Principles

Principle 1 — Human Accountability

AI systems may analyze information, generate recommendations, coordinate activities, or execute approved actions.

Final accountability remains with appropriately authorized human leaders.

Principle 2 — Dynamic Decision Boundaries

Decision authority should not remain static.

Organizations should continuously review and adjust AI decision boundaries based on:

- Performance
- Business context

- Regulatory change
- Operational experience
- Emerging risks
- Governance effectiveness

Principle 3 — Multi-Agent Governance

Organizations increasingly deploy multiple AI agents working together.

Governance should therefore address:

- Agent coordination
- Shared decision-making
- Data exchange
- Escalation paths
- Oversight responsibilities
- Ecosystem resilience

Principle 4 — Independent Assurance

Internal Audit provides independent assurance over governance effectiveness.

Internal Audit may use AI-enabled analytics and automation for assurance activities while remaining independent from management's ownership and operation of AI controls.

Principle 5 — Continuous Improvement

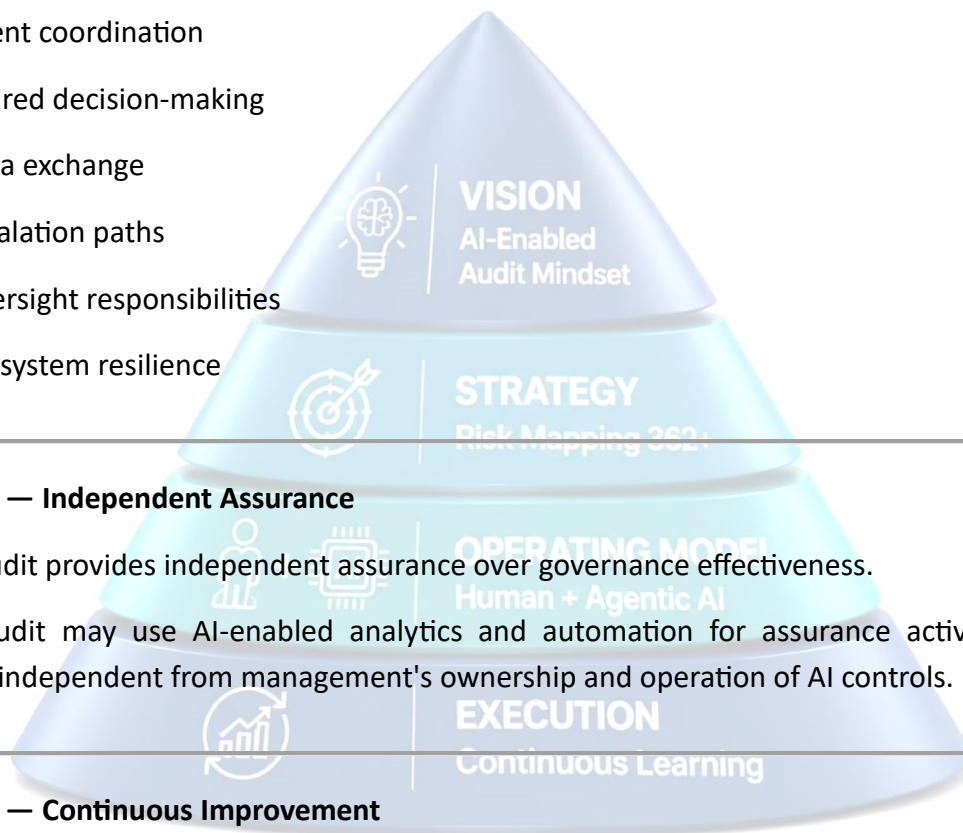
Governance is an ongoing process rather than a one-time implementation.

Organizations should periodically assess:

- Governance effectiveness
- Decision quality
- Control performance

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- Human oversight
- Operational resilience
- Lessons learned

and update governance arrangements accordingly.

1.3 Governance Model

The Strategy Cone™ organizes governance into five integrated layers:

Vision Layer

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Defines the organization's long-term AI governance ambition and strategic direction.

Strategy Layer

Establishes governance principles, decision boundaries, accountability, and oversight.

Operating Model Layer

Defines roles, responsibilities, approvals, escalation paths, and governance processes.

Execution Layer

Supports AI-enabled activities, monitoring, reporting, and continuous decision evaluation.

Enterprise Integration Layer

Connects governance with enterprise systems including GRC, ERP, identity management, operational platforms, and monitoring capabilities.

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1.4 Governance Outcomes

Successful implementation should enable organizations to:

- Improve governance transparency.

- Strengthen accountability.
- Increase confidence in AI-supported decisions.
- Enhance Internal Audit assurance.
- Improve governance reporting.
- Support enterprise-scale AI adoption.
- Strengthen resilience through continuous monitoring.
- Promote responsible and trustworthy AI use.

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SECTION 2 — Dynamic Decision Boundary Framework

2.1 Purpose

Dynamic Decision Boundaries are the primary governance mechanism within The Futurist's Strategy Cone™.

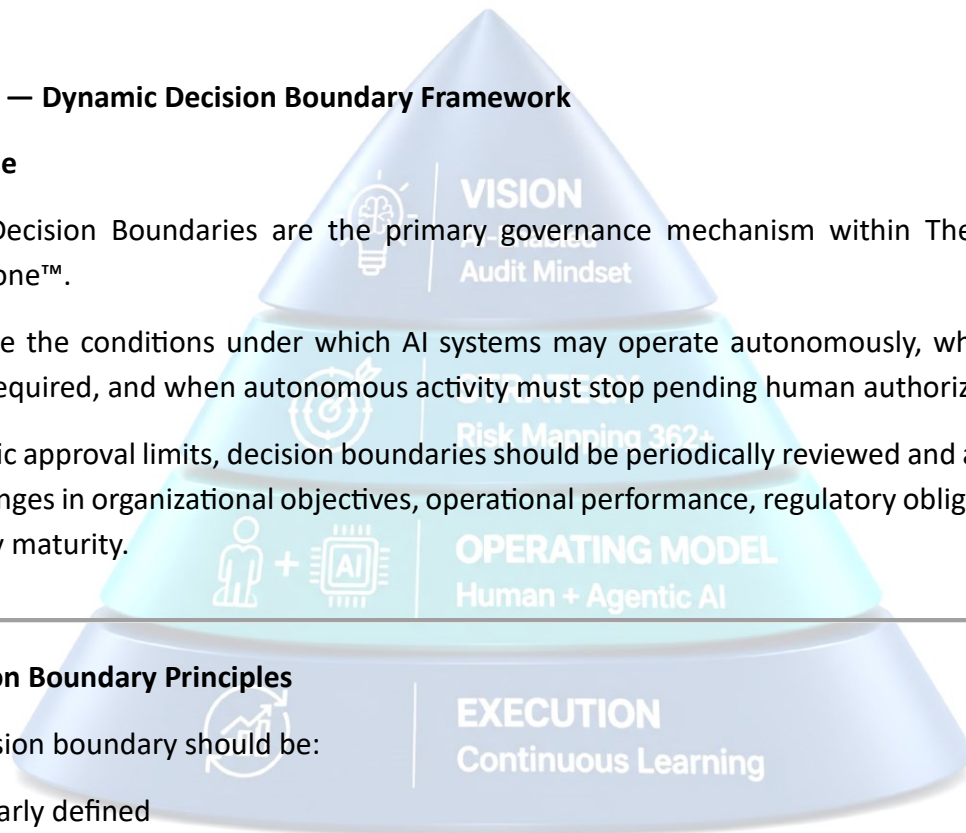
They define the conditions under which AI systems may operate autonomously, when human review is required, and when autonomous activity must stop pending human authorization.

Unlike static approval limits, decision boundaries should be periodically reviewed and adjusted to reflect changes in organizational objectives, operational performance, regulatory obligations, and technology maturity.

2.2 Decision Boundary Principles

Every decision boundary should be:

- Clearly defined
- Measurable
- Understandable
- Traceable
- Reviewable
- Proportionate to impact



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- Supported by evidence
- Subject to governance oversight

Decision boundaries should evolve through structured governance rather than ad hoc changes.

2.3 Governance Levels

Level 0 — Strategic Governance

Primary Accountability: Board and Executive Leadership

Focus: Reimagining Internal Audit for the Age of Agentic AI

- Strategic objectives
- Organizational values
- Risk tolerance approved by leadership
- Human accountability
- Enterprise AI strategy

Typical decisions:

- High-impact AI use cases
- Enterprise deployment approval
- Governance principles
- Material policy changes

Level 1 — Operational Governance

Primary Accountability: Executive Management

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- Business processes
- Operational controls
- Delegated authority
- Performance expectations

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- Exception management

Typical decisions:

- Operational thresholds
- Escalation criteria
- Business rule updates
- Workflow approvals

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Level 2 — AI Decision Governance

Focus:

- AI confidence thresholds
- Approved actions
- Decision scope
- Automation limits
- Human review triggers

Example controls:

- Confidence threshold
- Data quality checks
- Source validation
- Approval routing
- Explainability requirements



2.4 Boundary Lifecycle

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Every decision boundary follows a governance lifecycle:

Define



Approve



Implement



Monitor



Evaluate



Adjust



Re-Approve



Continue Monitoring

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This lifecycle helps maintain governance as organizational conditions evolve.

2.5 Boundary Categories

Strategic Boundaries

Examples include:

- Regulatory obligations
 - Financial materiality
 - Ethical principles
 - Brand reputation
 - Enterprise objectives
-

Operational Boundaries

Examples include:

- Approval authority
 - Transaction thresholds
 - Service levels
 - Exception handling
 - Workflow routing
-

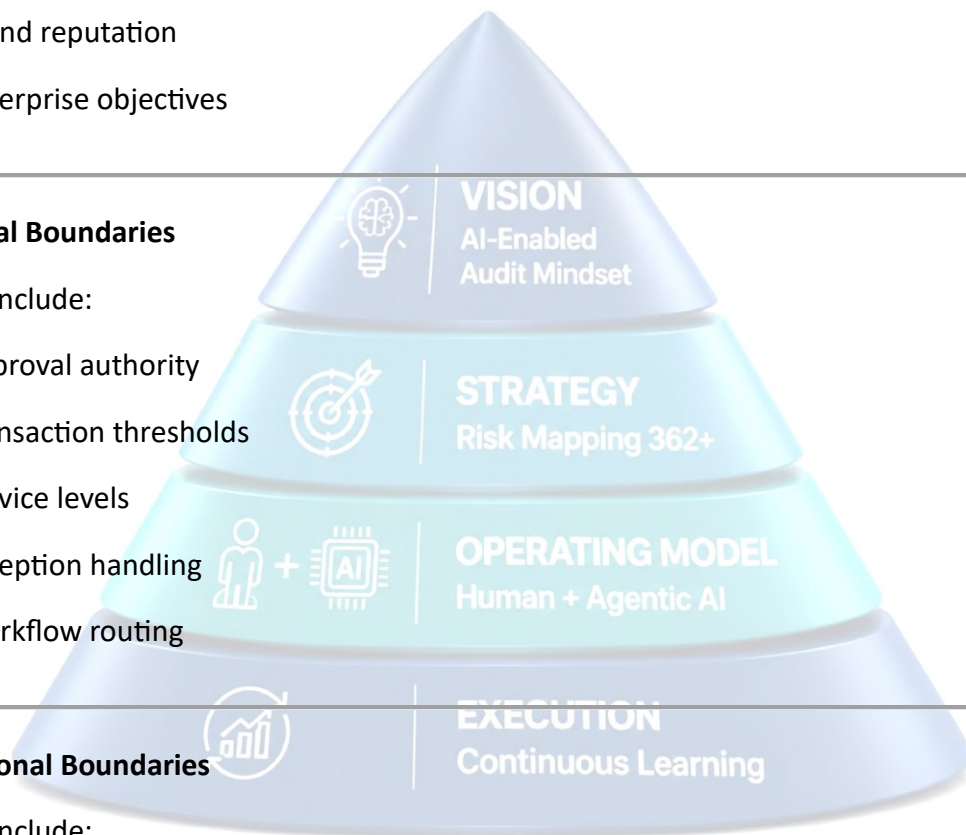
AI Operational Boundaries

Examples include:

- Confidence requirements
- Response time limits
- Data source restrictions
- Tool permissions
- Automation limits

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Ecosystem Boundaries

Applicable to multi-agent environments.

Examples include:

- Agent coordination
- Task delegation
- Shared memory controls
- Communication protocols
- Escalation rules

2.6 Boundary Review Triggers

Organizations should consider reviewing boundaries when:

- Business strategy changes
- Regulations change
- AI performance declines
- Significant incidents occur
- New AI capabilities are introduced
- Internal Audit identifies governance weaknesses
- Material organizational restructuring occurs

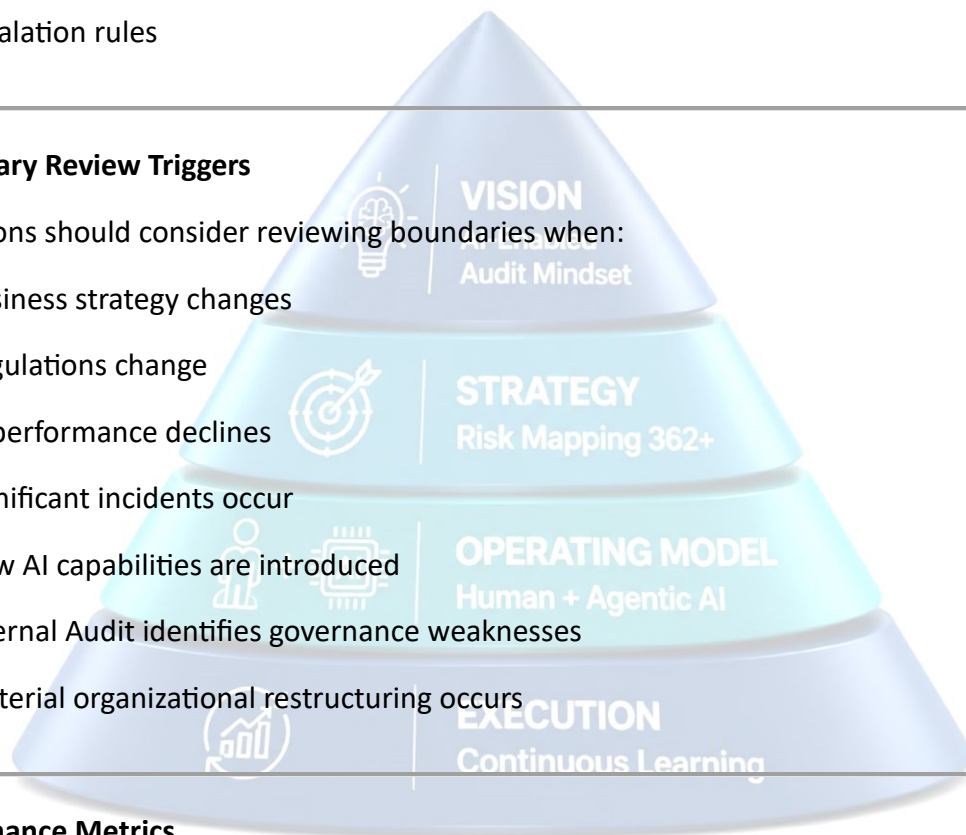
2.7 Governance Metrics

Illustrative governance indicators include:

- Boundary compliance rate
- Human intervention rate
- Exception frequency
- Decision quality

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- Governance review completion
- Policy update timeliness
- Audit observations
- Improvement actions completed

Organizations should tailor metrics to their operating environment.

SECTION 3 — Enterprise Integration Architecture

3.1 Purpose

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AI governance should complement—not replace—existing enterprise governance arrangements.

The Strategy Cone™ encourages integration with established organizational processes to reduce duplication and improve governance consistency.

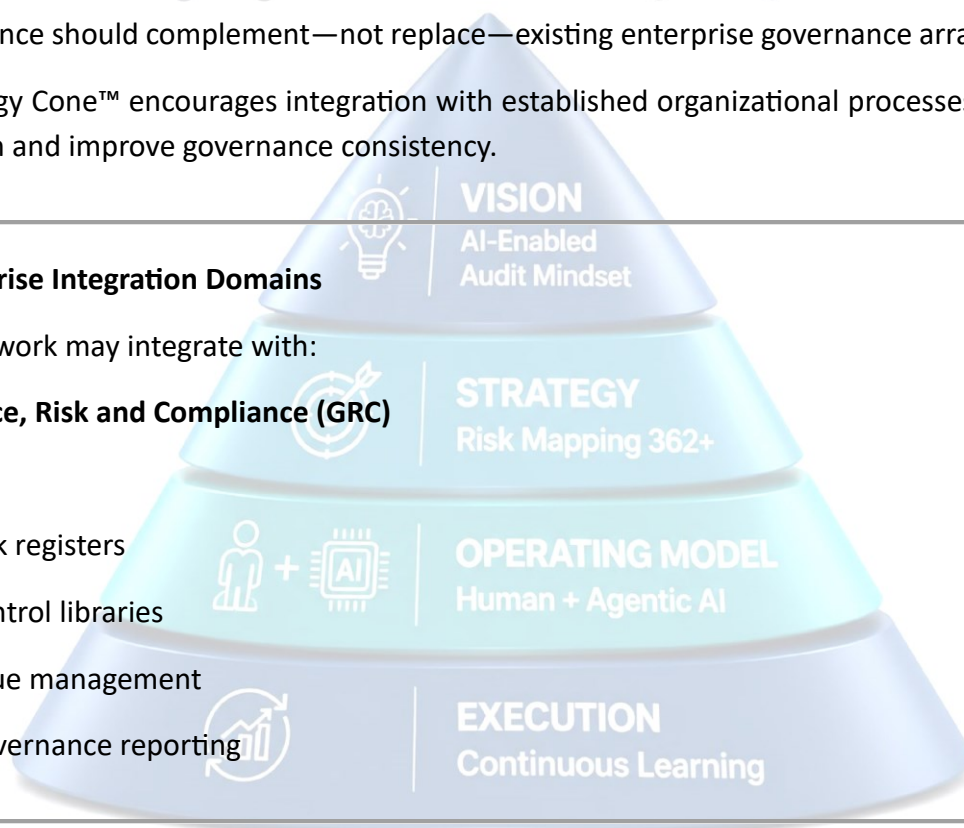
3.2 Enterprise Integration Domains

The framework may integrate with:

Governance, Risk and Compliance (GRC)

Supports:

- Risk registers
- Control libraries
- Issue management
- Governance reporting



Enterprise Resource Planning (ERP)

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Supports:

- Financial processes
- Operational transactions
- Business data

- Resource planning

Identity and Access Management

Supports:

- User authentication
- Role-based access
- Segregation of duties
- Privileged access governance

IT Service Management

Supports:

- Incident management
- Change management
- Configuration management
- Service requests

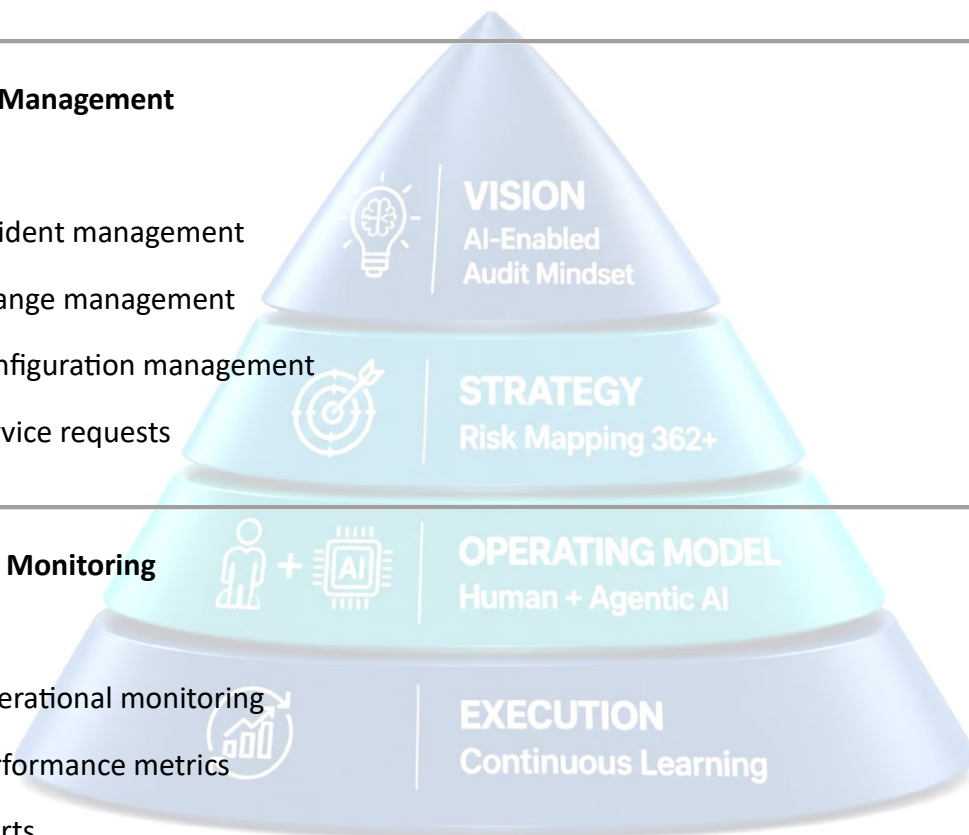
Enterprise Monitoring

Supports:

- Operational monitoring
- Performance metrics
- Alerts
- Logging
- Observability

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3.3 Multi-Agent Governance

Organizations may deploy multiple AI agents performing complementary responsibilities.

Typical roles include:

Orchestrator Agent

Coordinates workflows.

Specialist Agents

Perform domain-specific tasks.

Review Agent

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Evaluates outputs generated by other agents.

Monitoring Agent

Observes operational health and governance indicators.

Human Oversight

Provides governance, approval, accountability, and intervention when required.

3.4 Governance Principles for Multi-Agent Systems

Organizations should establish:

- Clear agent responsibilities
- Defined communication protocols
- Escalation mechanisms
- Approval requirements
- Human intervention criteria
- Monitoring responsibilities
- Incident response procedures

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3.5 Enterprise Deployment Journey

Illustrative maturity stages:

Stage 1 — Pilot

Objectives:

- Limited deployment
- Governance design
- Initial monitoring

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Stage 2 — Controlled Expansion

Objectives:

- Multiple business processes
- Governance refinement
- Performance evaluation

Stage 3 — Enterprise Adoption

Objectives:

- Cross-functional integration
- Standardized governance
- Continuous monitoring

Stage 4 — Continuous Optimization

Objectives:

- Governance improvement
- Lessons learned
- Organizational learning
- Ongoing assurance

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3.6 Integration Principles

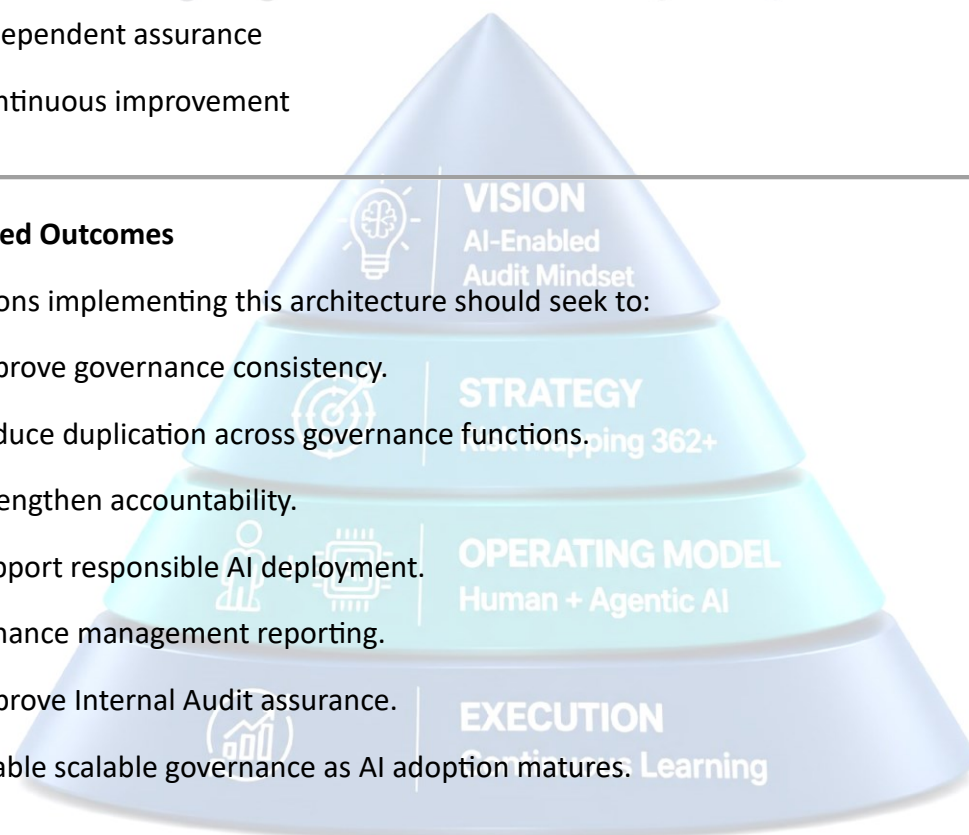
Successful enterprise AI governance should emphasize:

- Governance before automation
- Human accountability
- Transparency
- Explainability where appropriate
- Operational resilience
- Independent assurance
- Continuous improvement

3.7 Expected Outcomes

Organizations implementing this architecture should seek to:

- Improve governance consistency.
- Reduce duplication across governance functions.
- Strengthen accountability.
- Support responsible AI deployment.
- Enhance management reporting.
- Improve Internal Audit assurance.
- Enable scalable governance as AI adoption matures.



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SECTION 4 — Human Accountability Framework

4.1 Purpose

Human accountability remains the foundation of responsible Agentic AI governance.

While AI systems may automate analysis, generate recommendations, coordinate activities, or execute approved tasks, accountability for organizational decisions remains with authorized human decision-makers.

The objective of this framework is to ensure that increased automation does not reduce transparency, oversight, or responsibility.

4.2 Guiding Principle

AI Works. Humans Decide. Decision Boundaries Are Dynamic. Accountability Always Remains Human.

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Organizations should define, document, and periodically review decision rights for every AI-enabled process.

4.3 Human Accountability Model

Level 0 — Strategic Governance

Primary Accountability: Board of Directors and Executive Leadership

Responsibilities

- Approve enterprise AI strategy.
- Establish governance principles.
- Define organizational objectives.
- Approve material AI initiatives.
- Review enterprise governance reporting.
- Oversee organizational accountability.



Level 1 — Executive Governance

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Primary Accountability: Executive Management

Responsibilities

- Implement governance policies.

- Allocate resources.
- Establish operational controls.
- Monitor organizational performance.
- Escalate significant issues.
- Promote responsible AI adoption.

Level 2 — AI Governance

Primary Accountability: AI Governance Committee (or equivalent governance body)

Responsibilities

- Review AI use cases.
- Approve decision boundary changes.
- Monitor governance performance.
- Coordinate cross-functional oversight.
- Review significant incidents.
- Recommend governance improvements.

Level 3 — Operational Oversight

Primary Accountability: Business Process Owners

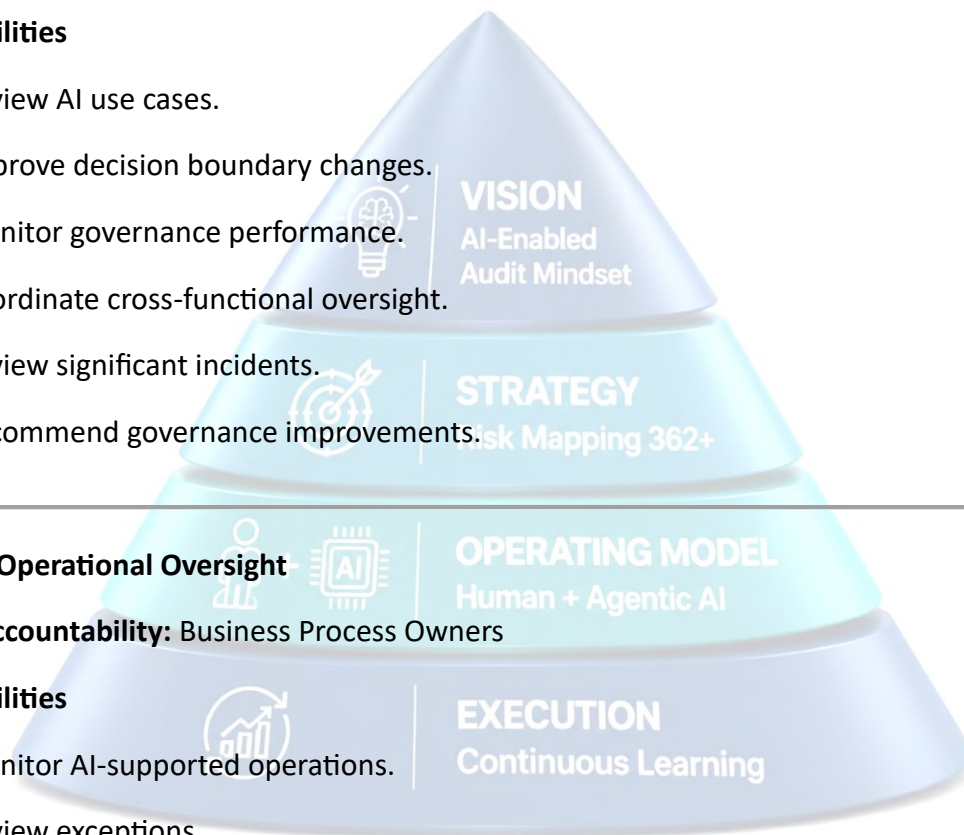
Responsibilities

- Monitor AI-supported operations.
- Review exceptions.
- Validate outputs where required.
- Escalate governance concerns.
- Maintain operational documentation.

Level 4 — Independent Assurance

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Primary Accountability: Chief Audit Executive / Internal Audit

Responsibilities

- Provide independent assurance.
- Evaluate governance effectiveness.
- Assess control design and operation.
- Report significant governance observations.
- Recommend improvement opportunities.

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4.4 Decision Authority Matrix

Activity	AI	Human
Data analysis	✓	Oversight
Pattern identification	✓	Review
Recommendations	✓	Approval where required
Routine execution within approved boundaries	✓	Monitoring
Exception handling	Assist	Decision
Policy approval	Support Human authority	
Strategic decisions	Support Human authority	
Accountability	No	Always human

4.5 Human Review Triggers

Organizations should define criteria requiring human intervention.

Illustrative examples include:

- Confidence below organizational threshold.
- Material financial impact.

- Regulatory implications.
- Ethical concerns.
- Significant customer impact.
- Conflicting recommendations.
- Data quality concerns.
- Boundary violations.
- Novel or previously unseen scenarios.

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4.6 Escalation Principles

Escalation should be:

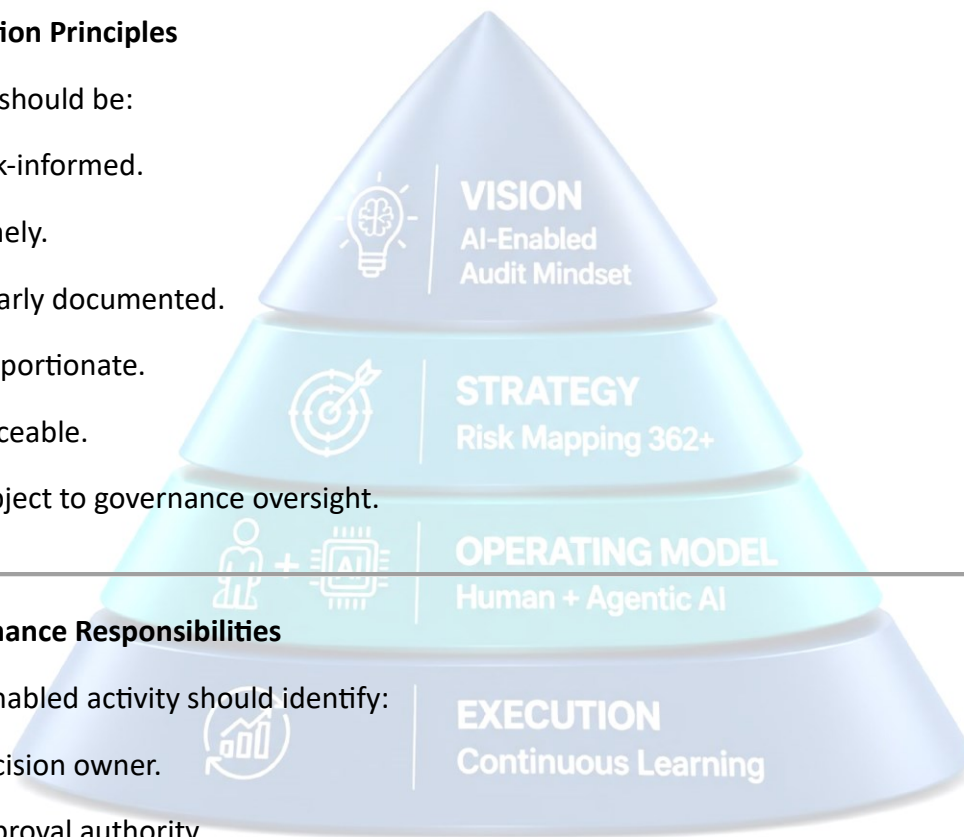
- Risk-informed.
- Timely.
- Clearly documented.
- Proportionate.
- Traceable.
- Subject to governance oversight.

4.7 Governance Responsibilities

Every AI-enabled activity should identify:

- Decision owner.
- Approval authority.
- Oversight function.
- Monitoring responsibility.
- Escalation authority.
- Assurance provider.

Clear accountability reduces ambiguity and strengthens governance.



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SECTION 5 — Enterprise Technical Governance Architecture

5.1 Purpose

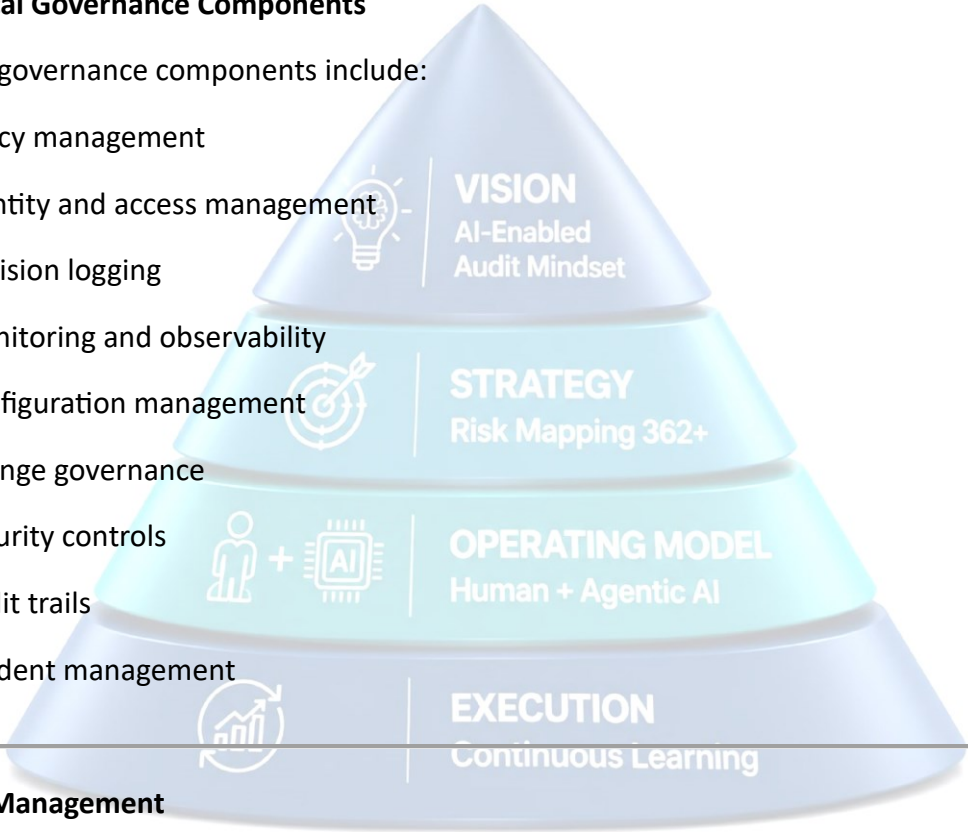
Technical controls support governance objectives.

Technology should reinforce governance decisions rather than replace governance judgment.

Organizations should adapt technical controls according to their operational environment, regulatory obligations, technology stack, and risk profile.

5.2 Technical Governance Components

Illustrative governance components include:

- 
- Policy management
 - Identity and access management
 - Decision logging
 - Monitoring and observability
 - Configuration management
 - Change governance
 - Security controls
 - Audit trails
 - Incident management

5.3 Policy Management

Organizations should establish controlled processes for:

- Creating policies.
- Reviewing policies.
- Approving changes.
- Version management.

- Documentation.
- Communication.
- Retirement of obsolete policies.

Changes should be appropriately authorized and recorded.

5.4 Identity and Access Governance

Access should follow organizational security principles, including:

- Least privilege.
- Role-based access.
- Separation of duties.
- Multi-factor authentication where appropriate.
- Periodic access review.
- Timely removal of unnecessary access.

5.5 Decision Logging

Decision records should support governance objectives by capturing information such as:

- Time of decision.
- Responsible process.
- AI involvement.
- Human approvals.
- Decision outcome.
- Supporting evidence.
- Relevant policy version.

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Organizations should define retention requirements consistent with applicable legal and regulatory obligations.

5.6 Monitoring and Observability

Monitoring should support timely identification of:

- Performance degradation.
- Operational incidents.
- Policy exceptions.
- Boundary breaches.
- Unexpected behaviour.
- Service interruptions.

Monitoring information should be reviewed by appropriate governance functions.

5.7 Change Governance

Organizations should establish documented processes for:

- Requesting changes.
- Assessing impacts.
- Approving modifications.
- Testing.
- Deployment.
- Post-implementation review.
- Lessons learned.

Material changes should receive appropriate governance oversight before implementation.

5.8 Operational Resilience

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Governance should consider:

- Business continuity.
- Disaster recovery.
- Incident response.

- Service restoration.
- Backup arrangements.
- Recovery testing.

Organizations should periodically evaluate resilience capabilities.

5.9 Information Security

Illustrative governance practices include:

- Secure authentication.
- Encryption where appropriate.
- Network protection.
- Secure configuration.
- Vulnerability management.
- Security monitoring.
- Incident reporting.

Organizations should align security controls with their overall information security program.

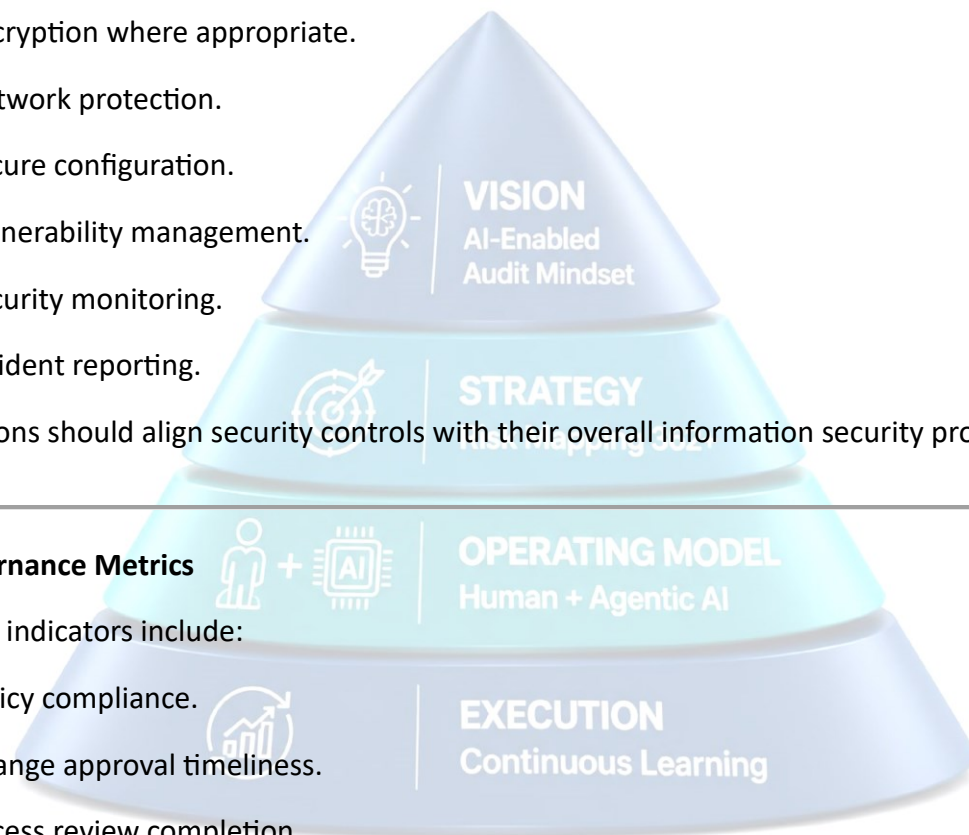
5.10 Governance Metrics

Illustrative indicators include:

- Policy compliance.
- Change approval timeliness.
- Access review completion.
- Incident trends.
- Monitoring coverage.
- Audit observations.
- Governance action completion.
- Continuous improvement progress.

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Metrics should support informed governance decisions rather than become objectives in themselves.

5.11 Governance Principles

Technology should support:

- Transparency.
- Accountability.
- Traceability.
- Reliability.
- Resilience.
- Continuous improvement.
- Human oversight.

Governance should remain the primary objective.

SECTION 6 — Internal Audit Assurance Framework

6.1 Purpose

Internal Audit provides **independent assurance** over the effectiveness of AI governance, risk management, and internal controls.

Internal Audit may use AI-enabled tools to improve assurance activities while remaining independent of management's ownership, operation, and day-to-day administration of AI systems.

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6.2 Guiding Principles

Internal Audit should:

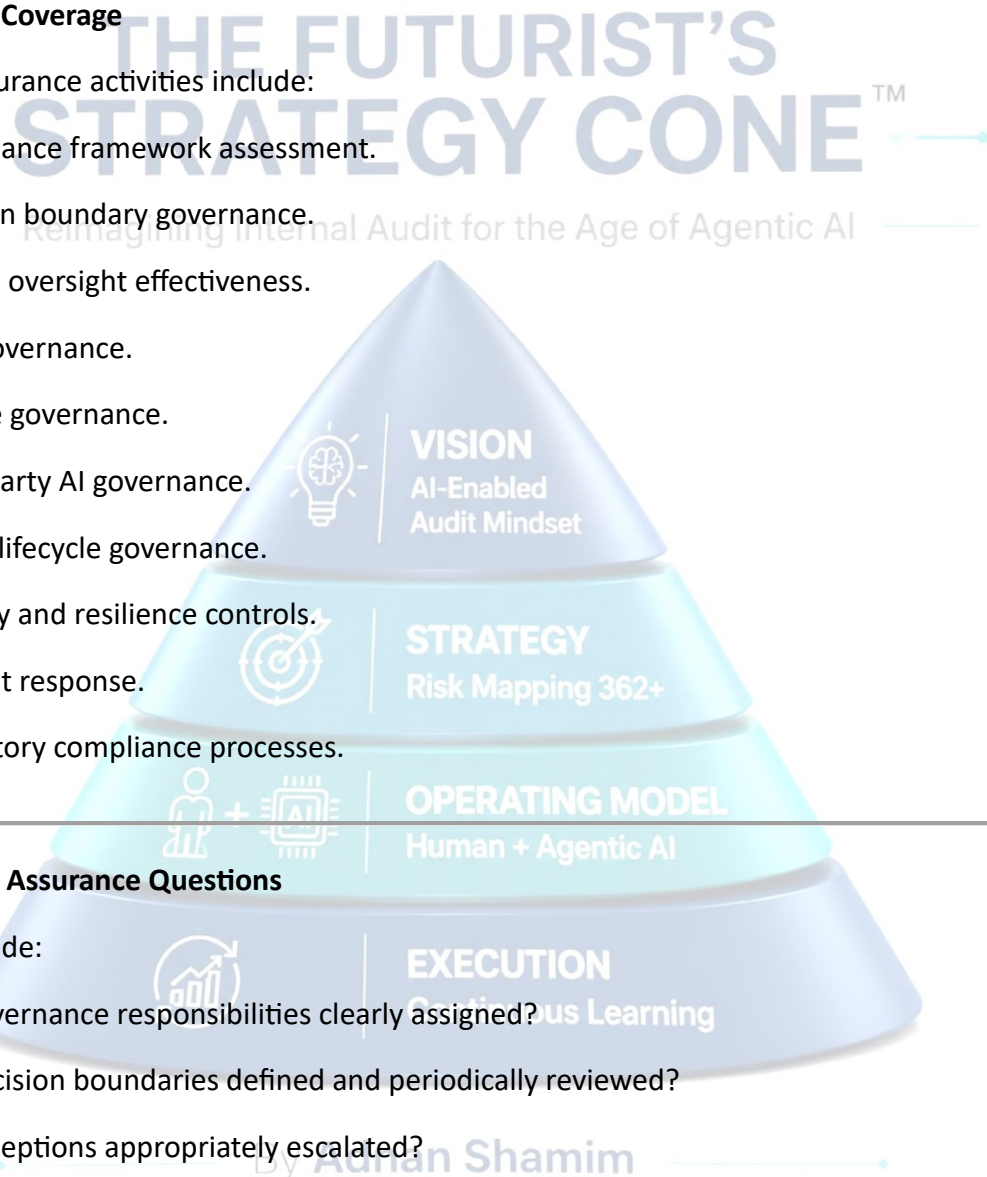
- Maintain organizational independence and objectivity.
- Evaluate governance design and operating effectiveness.

- Assess management's AI controls rather than operate them.
- Report significant observations to senior management and the Board.
- Support continuous improvement through independent recommendations.

6.3 Assurance Coverage

Illustrative assurance activities include:

- Governance framework assessment.
- Decision boundary governance.
- Human oversight effectiveness.
- Data governance.
- Change governance.
- Third-party AI governance.
- Model lifecycle governance.
- Security and resilience controls.
- Incident response.
- Regulatory compliance processes.



6.4 Illustrative Assurance Questions

Examples include:

- Are governance responsibilities clearly assigned?
- Are decision boundaries defined and periodically reviewed?
- Are exceptions appropriately escalated?
- Is human accountability maintained?
- Are governance changes documented and approved?
- Are monitoring and reporting processes effective?

SECTION 7 — Continuous Improvement Governance Cycle

Governance should evolve as organizational objectives, technology, regulation, and operating environments change.

Governance Lifecycle

Plan



Design



Implement



Monitor



Evaluate



Improve



Report



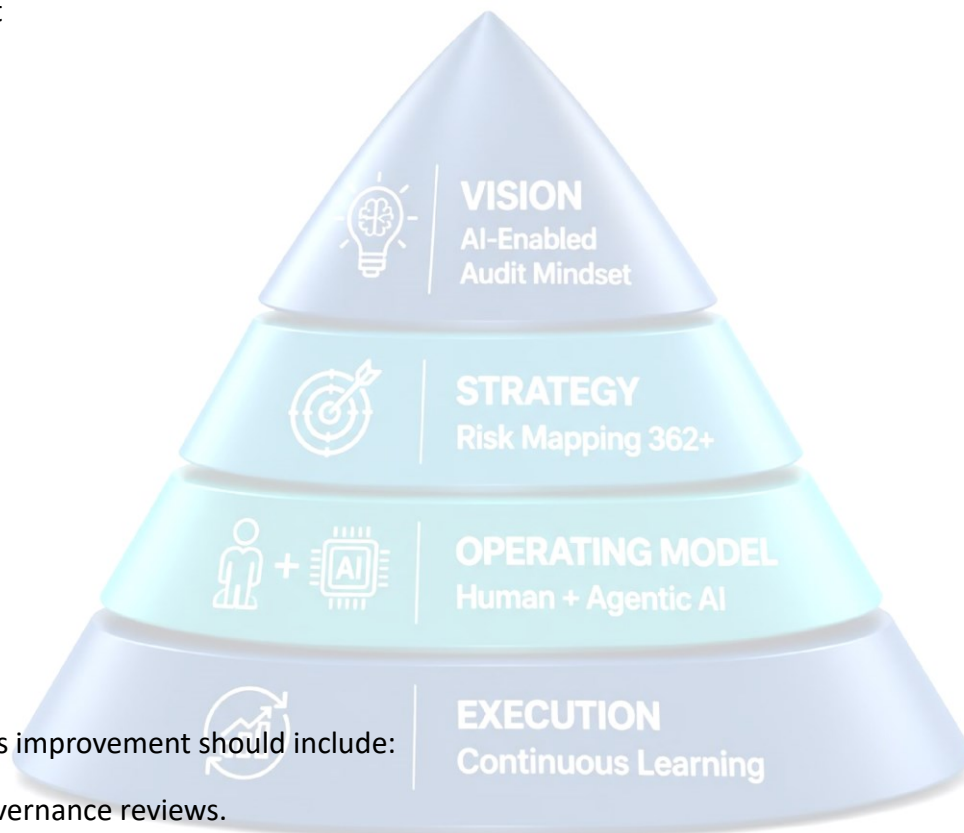
Repeat

Continuous improvement should include:

- Governance reviews.
- Lessons learned.
- Incident analysis.
- Internal Audit recommendations.
- Regulatory developments.
- Stakeholder feedback.

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- Technology changes.

SECTION 8 — Enterprise Adaptation Framework

The Strategy Cone™ is intended as a **reference architecture**, not a mandatory implementation methodology.

Organizations should tailor the framework according to:

- Industry sector.
- Organizational size.
- Governance maturity.
- Regulatory obligations.
- Technology architecture.
- Business objectives.
- Risk profile.

Illustrative adaptations may include:

- Financial services.
- Healthcare.
- Manufacturing.
- Government.
- Energy.
- Telecommunications.
- Retail.



SECTION 9 — Operational Testing Framework

Organizations should periodically test governance arrangements.

Illustrative scenarios include:

Scenario 1 — Decision Boundary Exception

Objective:

Evaluate whether governance processes correctly escalate exceptions beyond approved decision boundaries.

Scenario 2 — Unauthorized Change

Objective:

Confirm that unauthorized governance changes are detected, investigated, and addressed.

Scenario 3 — Monitoring Failure

Objective:

Assess organizational response when monitoring capabilities become unavailable or degraded.

Scenario 4 — Multi-Agent Coordination Failure

Objective:

Evaluate governance response when multiple AI agents produce inconsistent or conflicting outcomes.

Scenario 5 — Business Continuity Exercise

Objective:

Demonstrate the organization's ability to continue critical operations if AI capabilities become unavailable.

Testing results should be documented, reviewed, and incorporated into governance improvements.

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SECTION 10 — Enterprise Implementation Roadmap

Organizations may adopt the framework in phases.

Phase 1 — Foundation

- Establish governance responsibilities.
- Define decision boundaries.
- Develop governance documentation.
- Build AI awareness.

Phase 2 — Pilot

- Deploy limited AI capabilities.
- Evaluate governance effectiveness.
- Monitor operational performance.
- Capture lessons learned.

Phase 3 — Expansion

- Extend governance across additional business processes.
- Integrate with enterprise governance.
- Enhance reporting and monitoring.

Phase 4 — Optimization

- Mature governance capabilities.
- Refine decision boundaries.
- Strengthen assurance.
- Continuously improve governance performance.

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SECTION 11 — Governance Coverage Statement

The Strategy Cone™ v7.0 is designed to provide comprehensive governance guidance across the enterprise AI lifecycle, including:

- Strategic governance.

- Human accountability.
- Decision boundary management.
- Enterprise integration.
- Multi-agent governance.
- Internal Audit assurance.
- Change governance.
- Continuous monitoring.
- Operational resilience.
- Continuous improvement.

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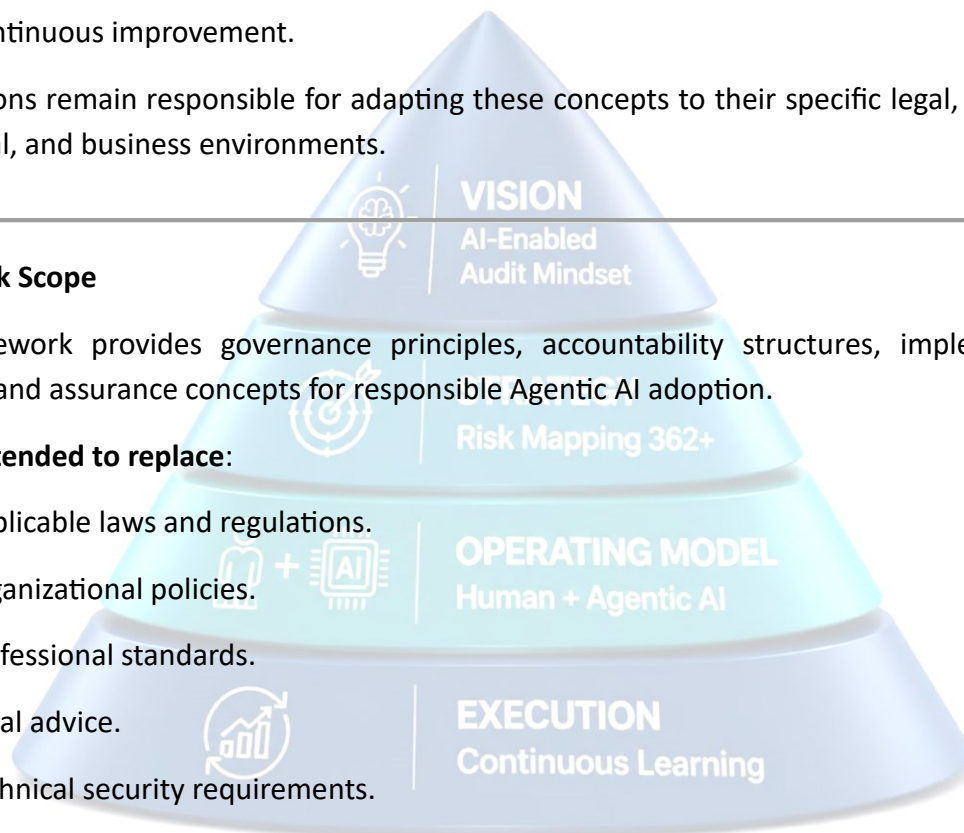
Organizations remain responsible for adapting these concepts to their specific legal, regulatory, operational, and business environments.

Framework Scope

This framework provides governance principles, accountability structures, implementation guidance, and assurance concepts for responsible Agentic AI adoption.

It is **not intended to replace**:

- Applicable laws and regulations.
- Organizational policies.
- Professional standards.
- Legal advice.
- Technical security requirements.
- Professional judgement.



Ultimate accountability remains with authorized human decision-makers.

Future Development Roadmap

Future editions may incorporate:

- Enterprise implementation case studies.

- Independent peer review.
- Academic collaboration.
- Governance maturity assessments.
- Cross-industry benchmarking.
- Practical implementation guides.
- Metrics informed by organizational experience.

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Closing Statement

Reimagining Internal Audit for the Age of Agentic AI

THE FUTURIST'S STRATEGY CONE™ v7.0 is an independently developed governance framework intended to support responsible, transparent, and accountable adoption of Agentic AI.

It is offered as a practical reference architecture that organizations may adapt to strengthen governance, clarify accountability, improve assurance, and support informed human decision-making as AI capabilities continue to evolve.

Guiding Principle

AI Works. Humans Decide. Decision Boundaries Are Dynamic. Accountability Always Remains Human.

Version 7.0 Summary

Edition: Enterprise Reference Edition

Core Characteristics

- Independent governance framework.
- Human-centered accountability.
- Dynamic decision boundary governance.
- Enterprise integration guidance.
- Multi-agent governance concepts.
- Internal Audit assurance model.

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- Continuous governance improvement.
- Adaptable across industries and jurisdictions.
- Scalable reference architecture for enterprise AI governance.

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Reimagining Internal Audit for the Age of Agentic AI



By **Adnan Shamim**